14.1 STRAIGHT POOL

Straight Pool - Standard Rules

The WPA game written out plainly for Columbia Cue Club, with our score sheet behind it.

ABOUT 14.1 CONTINUOUS

Straight pool is the game the others borrowed from. Fifteen balls, and every ball pocketed on a called shot is one point. Nothing resets between racks: once fourteen balls are down the fifteenth stays on the table as the break ball and the rest are re-racked, so a run carries straight on into the next rack. Fouls cost a point, which is why a score can go negative. The first player to the target wins - 75 or 100 at the club, 125 or 150 if the match is a long one.

NOTHING HERE CHANGES THE GAME

This document is the WPA's 14.1 Continuous rules, written out in plain English so a new player can read them at the table. The WPA Rules of Play is the authority: if this page and that book ever disagree, the book wins. Rule numbers below are the WPA's own, so the two can be read side by side.

HOW TO READ THIS DOCUMENT

Every rule heading carries a source chip. Look for these:

[WPA] The WPA rule, written out plainly. No club change.

[Club] Club practice: the bits our score sheet and targets add.

VERSION

14.1 Straight Pool Rules v1.0

EFFECTIVE

October 2026

Scan: WPA Rules of Play (14.1 Continuous)

wpapool.com/rules/

Aligned to the WPA Rules of Play, effective 2026-01-02.

THE RULES

These are the rules of 14.1 Continuous, in the order the WPA sets them out. Everything the WPA says about general play - lagging for the break, calling a shot, cue ball in hand, spotting balls, a stalemate - applies here as it does in every other discipline, so it is summarised rather than repeated.

4.1 LAGGING FOR THE BREAK [WPA]

Players lag to decide who breaks. Nothing special about it here - the same lag as any other game.

4.2 THE RACK [WPA]

Fifteen balls in a triangle with the apex ball on the foot spot. When fourteen balls are re-racked mid-game, the apex ball is left out, so the triangle holds fourteen. The shape left on the cloth is what decides whether a ball is in the rack area.

4.3 THE OPENING BREAK [WPA]

The cue ball starts in hand behind the head string. If you do not pocket a called ball, the cue ball and two object balls must each reach a rail - miss that and it is a breaking foul, which costs two points. The incoming player then takes the table as it lies, or can ask you to break again until you satisfy it.

- A break that satisfies this and pockets nothing is just an inning change. You do not score for a ball that drops uncalled on the break.

4.4 STAYING AT THE TABLE, AND WINNING [WPA]

Keep pocketing called balls and you keep shooting. When fourteen balls of a rack have gone down, play stops until the balls are re-racked, and then you carry on - the run does not end at a rack boundary. The match ends when someone reaches the target score.

- That is the whole game: runs cross racks, and the only thing that ends an inning is a miss, a foul, or a called safety.

4.5 CALLING SHOTS AND SAFETIES [WPA]

Call the ball and the pocket on every shot. You can also call a safety: play then passes to your opponent at the end of the shot, and anything you pocketed on it is spotted rather than scored.

4.6 SPOTTING BALLS [WPA]

Balls pocketed on a foul, on a safety, or without a called ball having been pocketed get spotted, as does any ball driven off the table. If the fifteenth ball of a rack needs spotting while the other fourteen are untouched, it goes on the apex spot.

4.7 SCORING [WPA]

One point for every ball pocketed on a called shot. If another ball drops on the same shot, that counts too - one point each. Fouls come straight off your score, so a score of minus one or minus two is normal enough.

- The sheet adds the columns up for you: balls made, minus fouls, is the rack total, and the rack total adds to the running total.

4.8 WHEN BALLS ARE IN THE WAY OF THE RACK [WPA]

Sometimes the cue ball or the fifteenth ball is sitting in the rack area and cannot stay there. Then:

- Both interfering - all fifteen balls are re-racked and the cue ball is in hand behind the head string.
- Fifteenth ball only - it goes on the head spot, or the centre spot if the cue ball is in the way.
- Cue ball only - it is in hand behind the head string if the fifteenth ball is on or in front of it, otherwise it goes on the head spot (or the centre spot if that is blocked).
- Whichever it is, the shooter may play any ball first in the new rack.

4.9 STANDARD FOULS [WPA]

A standard foul costs one point, balls are spotted as needed, and the inning passes. The cue ball stays where it finished - with one exception, a scratch, where the incoming player gets the cue ball in hand behind the head string. The usual list:

- Cue ball in a pocket or off the table.
- No rail after contact - nothing reaches a cushion after the cue ball touches a ball.
- A ball driven off the table.

- Touching a ball by hand, cue, chalk or clothing.
- Double hit, or pushing through a frozen ball.
- Playing out of turn, or shooting while balls are still moving.
- Placing the cue ball badly, or playing a ball from behind the head string when it is not allowed.
- Slow play, at the referee's discretion.

4.10 BREAKING FOULS [WPA]

A breaking foul costs two points instead of one, and the opponent can make you break again. If a shot is both a breaking foul and a standard foul, it is counted as a breaking foul - two points, not three.

4.11 THREE FOULS IN A ROW [WPA]

Three consecutive standard fouls cost fifteen more points on top of the usual ones, the balls are re-racked, and the offender has to break again under the opening-break rule. A breaking foul does not count towards the three. Unsportsmanlike conduct is whatever the referee decides it is worth.

4.12 STALEMATE [WPA]

If the game gets stuck and neither player is making progress, the players lag again for the break.

THE SHEET, AND HOW WE RUN IT

Club 1 TARGETS [Club]

We score to 75 or 100. The sheet has a box for each, plus a line for anything else - 125 or 150 happens in longer matches, and a target that size wants a second sheet, because eight racks is what fits on one.

- Each side carries its own target in the app, so uneven targets are a handicap rather than a mistake.

Club 2 FILLING IN THE RACKS [Club]

One circle per ball, marked as it drops, fourteen to a rack - the fifteenth ball is the break ball and stays on the table, so there is no circle for it. A rack that has gone right shows fourteen marks and no repeats.

- Rack total = marks minus fouls. Running total = the rack total plus the rack before it.
- Both players sign the winner's sheet. Marking your opponent's balls as well is courtesy, not a rule.

Club 3 THE APP [Club]

The same match can be scored on a phone: open the club's scoring link and the two players load into the app. Score in points rather than racks, set the target on the race line (it reads 'Points to 100' for this game), and submit the result when the match is over. The paper sheet and the app use the same numbers.